

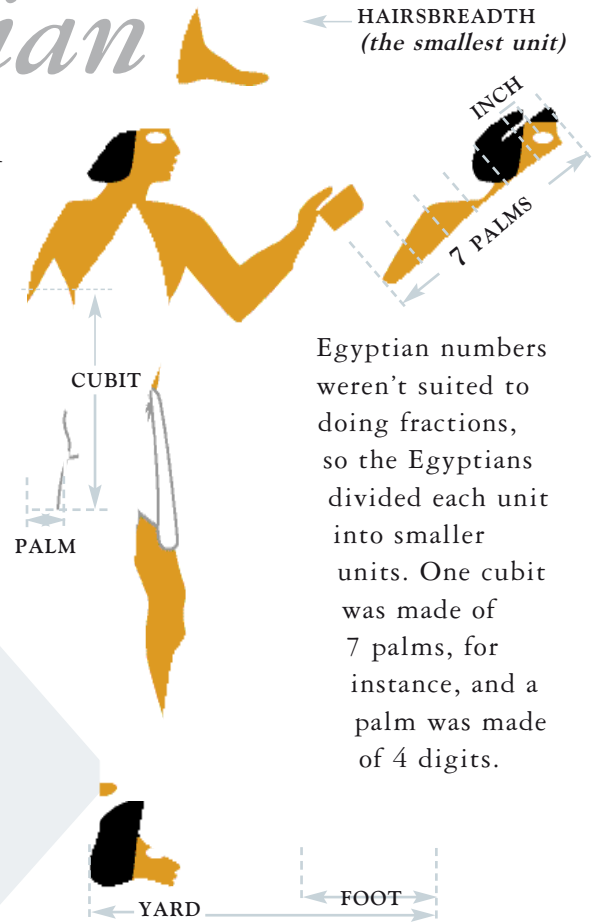


Work like an *Egyptian*

The ancient Egyptians farmed the thin ribbon of green land by the **River Nile**, which crosses the **Sahara Desert**. The Nile used to flood every summer, washing away fields and ditches. Year after year, the Egyptians had to mark out their fields anew. And so they became expert surveyors and timekeepers, using maths not just for counting but for measuring land, making buildings, and tracking time.



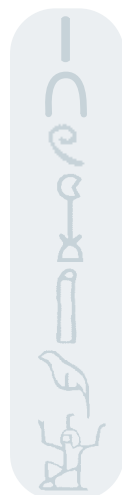
To measure anything – whether it's time, weight, or distance – you need units. The Egyptians based their units for length on the human body. Even today, some people still measure their height in “feet”.



Egyptian numbers weren't suited to doing fractions, so the Egyptians divided each unit into smaller units. One cubit was made of 7 palms, for instance, and a palm was made of 4 digits.

EGYPTIAN *numbers*

Egyptians counted in base 10 and wrote numbers as little pictures, or “hieroglyphs”. Simple lines stood for 1, 10, and 100. For 1000 they drew a lotus flower, 10,000 was a finger, 100,000 was a frog, and a million was a god.



1
10
100
1000
10,000
100,000
1,000,000

The hieroglyphs were stacked up in piles to create bigger numbers. This is how the Egyptians wrote 1996:



While hieroglyphs were carved in stone, a different system was used for writing on paper.